Silver in cultures and traditions

Silver is a colour that people long thought was “obvious”. Purity, the moon, second place. Behind its reputation, though, are **more stories about trade, faith and craft than about the colour itself**. Let us look at a few places and read them well.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how silver is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image, not as a guide. What is verified history and what a later interpretation, I say in each part.

Silver in different cultures

Czechia

Silver began to be mined in Kutná Hora in 1260 and around 1300 King Wenceslas II issued the mining code Ius regale montanorum. Soon afterwards the main mint of the Czech lands arose there, where the Prague groschen were struck. The Italian Court served as the royal mint from 1300 to 1727.

From a town that grew from a hill of silver into the second most important in the kingdom.

Silver here is **a gift of the land that turned into power**.

Bolivia

Potosí arose in 1545 as a mining settlement and Cerro Rico supplied a large part of the silver that financed the Spanish Empire. The mint struck pieces of eight there. Around 1600 it was the second largest city in the world.

From a mountain that shone so that its name became a byword for wealth.

Silver here is **a metal that moved the world**.

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France

In 1839 the daguerreotype was publicly announced. A copper plate coated with silver was polished to a mirror, exposed to iodine vapours and after exposure the image was developed with mercury vapours. The result was a unique image on a mirror surface.

From Paris, where light was first written into silver.

Silver here is **memory stored in metal**.

Germany

In 1835 the chemist Justus von Liebig developed a procedure in which a thin layer of silver is chemically applied to glass. Many more mirrors could thus be produced at a much lower price.

From a laboratory from which the mirror reached every home.

Silver here is **a reflection that became a matter of course**.

Silver in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at silver **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and a source of inspiration, not a healing guide.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In the traditional system of five elements white is linked with metal, autumn, the lungs, the large intestine and grief. Silver is a metal, so in the tradition it is often read next to white. That is my own reflection, not a classical table.

How it relates to the colour silver. For our story the image can carry the thought of inhaling and exhaling, receiving and letting go. A silver piece of jewellery or light has nothing to arrange. It can merely accompany a moment when you allow yourself to be without duties. **Colour does not replace rest.**

And what if I asked you now?

“What do I no longer want to hold and what do I need to keep?”

Autumn and purity

Autumn in the tradition belongs to metal and to letting go. Silver can accompany tidying up, putting aside a duty or an empty shelf. The benefit is clarity, not cleansing.

Winter is not the end

Calm can restore strength. If it turns into a long closing-off in which you do not feel well, add a warm accent. **You do not have to choose one position for ever.**

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are not assigned to the doshas uniformly in the classical texts, so here you read **modern interpretations**, not an old table.

How it relates to the colour silver. In Ayurveda-inspired work we can ask about coolness, shine and heaviness. Silver does not give the same experience in every material. A matt silver fabric and a glossy metal are rather different worlds.

Pitta

This is how a woman is described who is purposeful, quick and thorough, and flares up easily. A cool silver can give a calming impression. Too sharp a shine, though, can irritate.

- **Matt and soft**
  Cooling and calm.
- **Beware of shine**
  A sharp glitter can be an extra stimulus.

Vata

This is how a woman is described who is imaginative and quick, but restless, and is often cold. A cold silver can strengthen the feeling of chill. Add a warm fabric and light. **It is best to notice how you really feel in it.**

- **Warm companion**
  Wool, wood, a candle.
- **Evening**
  Soft light instead of harsh.

Kapha

This is how a woman is described who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily becomes heavy. Silver can add lightness, but large cool areas weigh a space down. **Add movement and colour to them.**

- **A light accent**
  Jewellery, a lamp, a mirror.
- **Add colour**
  Green or pink as a counterbalance.

We will therefore not make silver a universal ban or a remedy for a particular dosha. More interesting is whether a particular form brings you comfort or weighs on you.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

Jung did not describe silver as a separate colour. What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his thought, not his statement. In alchemy silver is linked with the Moon and gold with the Sun, and Jung read alchemy as an image of inner transformation. In such a reading silver can mean **the softer, quieter pole of inner light**.

How it relates to the colour silver. In symbolic language you can read silver as **the colour of reflection and perspective**. When you think about it, ask what in it is yours and what belongs to the expectations of others.

What you can take from it. Jung did not want colours to be made into a dictionary. **We always ask what it means for you.** The same silver can be a support for one woman and pressure for another. Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic framework, not verified science.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging a space so that it is good to live in. In feng shui interpretations silver and metallic colours are often assigned to the element of metal. Schools differ in the assignment, so take it as one of the possibilities.

Silver is like a mirror

A little adds shine to a space, a whole room turns it into a cold hall. Mirrors and silver work when there is room to rest in them.

Simple tips

- **Start small**
  A silver frame, candlestick or lamp. A silver frame does not behave like a silver wall.
- **Choose matt**
  A matt silver feels quieter than a glossy one.
- **Give it warmth**
  Wood, linen, a candle and warm light soften it.
- **Watch the mirrors**
  A mirror opposite the bed or the door often creates a feeling of restlessness. Try another place.
- **Try it in daylight**
  See how it looks in the morning and in the evening.
- **Try textiles first**
  Before you repaint a wall, try a cushion or a larger sample.

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What people say and what holds true

MYTH Silver goes black because it is dirty.

TRUTH Silver reacts with a small amount of sulphur in the air and forms a dark coating. That is normal and it can be polished away.

MYTH Silver is cold and impersonal.

TRUTH It depends on the surface. Brushed or matt silver next to wood and linen feels softer than shine and glass.

MYTH Gold and silver must not be mixed.

TRUTH That is an older rule. Today they are mixed, just watch the proportion and unify the surfaces.

What silver works well with

- **White**
  A clean and light impression. Watch that it is not sterile.
- **Dark blue**
  A calm and deep pair.
- **Pink**
  Softens the coolness of silver.
- **Black**
  Elegant and firm. Watch the quantity.
- **Gold**
  A festive pair. Beware of too much shine.
- **Brown**
  A warm, earthy impression that grounds silver.

Elements

- **Metal**
  Silver is its natural representative. Watch that it does not dominate.
- **Water**
  Dark blue and black deepen it.
- **Earth**
  Brown and yellow warm it.
- **Wood**
  Green and wood enliven it.

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Feng shui room by room

Living room

What works. A silver frame, candlestick or lamp can add an elegant detail.

What to watch for. When all the mirrors, frames and candlesticks are silver, the room feels cold.

A simple tip. Leave one more striking piece and warmer materials around it.

Kitchen and dining room

What works. Stainless steel and silver details are practical and clean.

What to watch for. Shine shows every fingerprint and limescale.

A simple tip. Choose a matt surface or brushed metal. Add wood and textile.

Bedroom

What works. A soft silver fabric or lamp can give a room a calm impression.

What to watch for. A mirror opposite the bed reflects light and movement and bothers many people.

A simple tip. Try a matt and muted silver. Let the light be warm.

Children's room

What works. A silver star, moon or frame can be play for a child.

What to watch for. A silver wall can turn cold. A child may not want it.

A simple tip. Let the child choose and start with a small detail.

Study

What works. A silver detail on the desk can recall calm and order.

What to watch for. Glossy surfaces around a screen cause reflections.

A simple tip. Leave one accent, mute the rest.

Bathroom

What works. Chrome and silver details give a fresh and clean impression.

What to watch for. Limescale and fingerprints on a glossy surface show more than you imagined.

A simple tip. Consider a matt finish and diffused light.

And try answering now

“Why do I want silver at home? What is it meant to bring me, calm, elegance, or distance?”

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